

ISBN CH-01

CONTEXT

PROCESS

WORKBOOK

“I’ve bought some art books from small publishers. They have ISBNs, but some of the more revealing paintings in them haven’t passed censorship. They’ll print the unapproved paintings in separate booklets as freebies, which is one way to do it. Another method, as mentioned in the comments, is to sell in the name of posters, necklaces, brooches, and the booklet comes as a free notebook to the product in sale”

comment
under a thread on
independent pub-
lishing in China



OBJECT
AS
BOOK

BOOK
AS
OBJECT

In September 2023, an enforcement team from the Shanghai Cultural and Tourism Bureau conducted an investigation and confiscated independent publications found in the office of the publishing unit 51 Personae.

An experimental field of publishing

In November 2024, a designer posted on X claiming that the founder of Jiazazhi had been arrested. The post received comments containing hearsay and informal sources, which offered fragmented glimpses into the incident, though no official confirmation or detailed report has been released. The scale of shock and its influence, however, is widely acknowledged within the local art, design, and independent publishing community.

“Cannot Say Goodbye”

In January 2025, Jiazazhi posted on its WeChat official account that it would be returning as an “art café” (a status that remains in place today), rather than operating as an independent bookstore, citing unspecified circumstances shortly after the alleged arrest and release of its founder.

“Can we still do small-scale art publishing in China? Yes, but collaboration with local publishers is necessary. Alternatively, one could partner with international publishers and legally import books through import/export companies. This would certainly increase costs and production time, but there is no other option for now.”

This statement was made by Jiazazhi’s founder, Yan You, in response to questions and concerns about the future of the publishing unit.

Financially Sustainable

Participatory

Learnable and Replicable

Discrete

Portable

Y Your work moves across so many different mediums. You make books, prints, digital works, and physical installations. I'm really curious what do you think about this expansive practice of yours. Do you still see yourself primarily as a graphic designer? Has that definition or role shifted for you over time? Could you share a bit more about your journey as a designer so far?

H I define myself as a multidisciplinary graphic designer. During undergrad, I double majored in graphic design and industrial design. I always wanted to go to grad school and study broadly, but I couldn't afford it at the time. That's why I started my career as a UX designer, because it felt like a more realistic way to earn money and eventually become a student again. So it wasn't really my dream job.

Even though it wasn't my final goal, that experience affected my life a lot. I like both print and digital media, so my original plan for grad school was: okay, I'm going to do half and half.

But after I came here, I realized that in the US everything is different—the paper sizes, the measurement systems. I had always used A4, A3, centimeters, millimeters as my language, but here you have inches and tabloids. So annoying!

Y Hahaha, I know.

H My English was really bad at the time, so I was afraid to go to the print shop, even though everyone there was actually very friendly. Because of that, I started doing more coding.

I didn't know coding languages deeply, but since I had worked as a UX designer for a long time, I already understood the structure from collaborating with developers. I knew things like: to execute this idea, I probably need this kind of library, or this kind of framework. I also knew the right terms and keywords to search for.

So when I first came here, I naturally moved toward digital and coding-based work. But after the first year, I realized: I really need to make print again. Because I love printing. That was actually the motivation behind Frozen Island. It started as a website, but eventually became a book.

Y It's so interesting that you said UX/UI was never really the ultimate design job for you. But at the same time, the attention you give to constructing an entire experience, something people move through across multiple objects and formats, feels deeply connected to that background.

Your projects are never just one thing. It's not simply: here's a book, done. Instead there's an app, a printer, a photographic machine, a book. This multi-channel interaction feels really central to your work.

And it also makes your projects feel so playful and open. They create connections not only between different media,

but also between the people encountering them.

I think you already touched a little on my second question, but: does juggling all these mediums ever feel challenging? Or does working between digital and analog feel intuitive and organic to you?

H I think it feels very organic and natural to me. I actually talked about this in my SOP for RISD, haha. My parents were book designers in the 1980s, which meant they made books completely by hand. There was no Adobe, no fancy digital tools. They didn't even use printers like we do now. They used typesetting machines to set the text. When I made things as a kid, my parents would tell me things like, "That's not the right way to draw a line," or "This is how you should cut paper." For them, their hands were the tools for designing and making. As a child, watching all of these processes shaped my first understanding of what graphic design was. Graphic design was what my parents did.

Then, when I grew up, there were smartphones and new technologies, and my first job was at Samsung as a UX designer for Galaxy phones. When I first joined, they were developing early flip-phone models. We made mockups for flexible and transparent displays, tested goggles, developed AI systems—and they also called that graphic design.

So going from this [making books by hand] to this [working with digital interfaces] felt like a huge leap. That experience made me realize that design is always changing, and all of these things are graphic design. We can keep pushing the boundary further, and every year the scope becomes bigger.

Y What you said about your parents' hands being their most trusted tools is so beautiful. Their craft became almost like muscle memory, both for them and for you.

I also wanted to zoom in on something else you mentioned: that making things simply makes people happy. As recent art school graduates, I think we all know how popular RISO workshops and hand-made zine culture are right now. Do you think this return to more tactile, "outdated" modes of production is a current trend in graphic design?

H I don't think it's just a design trend. I think graphic designers have always wanted authorship. Without techniques and machines like the risograph, it's actually very difficult to produce certain visual effects—like saturated spot colors—without spending huge amounts of money on industrial printing. That's one reason designers love RISO: it allows us to execute ideas quickly and affordably. And before risograph, there were copy machines. Photocopiers were also incredibly important tools for graphic designers and artists because they allowed people to produce and duplicate their own work independently.

If you look up copy machines and zines on Wikipedia, there are many examples showing how photocopy technology changed the way people created and

distributed work. It allowed people to truly own their production and dissemination process.

Y Since you brought up authorship, if I'm being very honest, it's always upsetting when people approach me and expect me to be nothing more than an executor of their ideas.

H Exactly. Personally, I define graphic design as art for everyone. Because of mass production, it became possible for everyone to own a piece of art. Before design, fine art was expensive. I might really love an artwork, but I couldn't have it. Art was singular, but design exists as multiples in the public.

For me, publishing is important to graphic designers because it allows one artwork to exist in many copies. It means that even if I don't have a lot of money, I can still own a piece of art. So when I think about the definition of design, I think of it as generous art for everyone.

Y I love that definition. And it leads perfectly into another aspect of your work, which is publishing. What's your relationship to publishing? In Chinese, we call it *chu ban* 出版.

H Oh! In Korean it's very similar: *chulpan* 출판. But please continue.

Y The character *ban* 版 specifically refers to the wooden plates used in woodblock printing. Meanwhile, in English, the word "publishing" contains the word "public" within it.* That difference in language is so intriguing to me.

H My definition of publishing is that it's a way to distribute my thoughts and art. As I said before, publishing is a generous way of distributing art. One part of it is accessibility, but another part is simply wanting to share ideas with other people. And when it comes to that, I think the medium itself doesn't really matter.

Y If we think about sharing something with others, books are still one of the most familiar formats—but different media also come with very different production costs. Making a book involves printing, binding, paper, ink, and materials, while posting work online can feel almost free in comparison. Do you think those differences in investment affect how people assign value to different media?

H This is just my personal perspective, but I think of it almost like a spectrum. Art is here [raises left fist high], printed books are somewhere in the middle, and digital media is here [lowers right fist].

When you visit a website, you can access everything instantly, anytime. But when we think about unique objects,

people often value them because they're one of a kind. Books sit somewhere in between. You can touch them, hold them, place them inside your home. So there's a stronger sense of affection toward a book than toward a website. The web, unlike your home, feels more like a public space for everyone. People don't really feel that a webpage belongs to them. But when we buy a book, we feel: "Okay, this is my book." When the same text and images circulate online, people tend to cherish them less.

Y That's such an interesting observation. If you think about it, we would absolutely buy a book as a gift for a friend. But I've never thought about gifting someone a website.

H Hahaha, yeah. Not many people do that.

Y It's fascinating how we consciously or unconsciously attach different kinds of intimacy to different media. Even though books are mass-produced, every copy still feels slightly singular in a way that digital content often doesn't.

Maybe that's why holding a book in your hands can feel more intimate than browsing the same thing online.

H Yes. The web is like a public park.

Y I love that. I can totally see how ideas of play, access, and gathering in your projects are wrapped up in that metaphor of the "public park."

Do you think that impulse comes more from your design philosophy, or is it something rooted in your personality?

H I would say both. It's part of my personality, but it's also intentional.

First, like I said before, I think graphic design is generous. We want to give our art to people in more accessible ways. But another reason is actually very personal. When I was four years old, my aunt committed suicide. I was too young to fully understand what had happened, but after that, my father became alcoholic and yelled a lot. I tried very hard to stay happy in a household that wasn't happy at all. My father was not an optimistic person. Part of me understood him, but another part of me believed that couldn't be the only way to live. So when I grew up, I wanted to prove him wrong. I wanted to prove that even in terrible situations, if we continue pursuing positive things and hold onto the hope of a better place, we can still connect with people, stay together, and find the strength to move forward. I wanted to prove that this was possible.

I think that's my manifesto. So yes, with my projects, I intentionally make choices that encourage people to come together.

Y Thank you for sharing that. I think it makes your work even more meaningful, because what you went through is deeply personal and difficult to process,

yet the work you create reaches people in such a lighthearted and generous way.

Y We love books. Why do you think the format of a book—or even an object more broadly—still feels so relevant and cherished by people?

H How should I put this... I think through objects, we build memories together, and those memories become part of ourselves.

That's why I often include interactive elements in my projects. For example, I have a website called Communal Radio Club. It's a kind of radio club where people can gather and listen to music together. I created a small listener list where visitors could leave their names.

It's always so fun because whenever I revisit the website, there's a new name appearing. It means people wanted to leave a trace and show their presence there. So again, I think of it like a park. Even though we don't physically see one another, everyone's traces and imprints become crystallized in the index.

Y You recently released your new book project, *Drops from the Air*, at the Multiple Formats book fair. Could you share more about the project?

H After I made *Frozen Island*, one of the organizers from the abC* book fair discovered it at another fair somewhere overseas. She looked up my work, found Communal Radio Club, really liked it, and reached out to me.

At the time, they couldn't import or sell *Frozen Island* because it didn't have an ISBN number, and they wanted to avoid any potential legal risks for the fair. So we decided it would be better for me to exhibit the work in a different form instead of as a book.

At first, we discussed presenting the *Frozen Island* archive through posters embedded with NFC tags. But I really loved the fair's theme, "Oneness in the Air," so I decided to create something more connected to that idea. That became *Air-Drop*. Through that project, I talked a lot about why publishing matters, especially under the political limitations happening in both of our countries.

We ended up having many really meaningful conversations there, and afterward I wanted to interview the abC team more deeply. When I came back to the US, I prepared for the interviews and spoke with them around June last year.

The production of the book was delayed a little because of Trump's tariff. Then during that time, abC invited me back for another exhibition. The new theme was "How Do You Meet the Book Again?" and I loved that theme too. So I continued developing *Air-Drop*, and eventually this year I published the book.

There was also another really interesting experience at

their recent Open M art fair. I saw many exhibitors selling stickers, illustration prints, posters, and things like that, so I assumed they were illustrators. But after talking to them and following them on Instagram, I suddenly realized: "Wait, you made this book? I own this book!" And it happened multiple times.

Y It's so interesting that you brought this up, because that observation was also one of the things that led me to this project in the first place.

Sometimes it feels like people are using prints, postcards, or other formats as a way of maneuvering around censorship, because those things are more often treated as commodities or merchandise rather than publications or cultural productions carrying a certain kind of political significance.

The moment we say the word "book," everyone suddenly becomes tense. But if you think about it materially, a book is simply an object made of bound pages, glue, and whatever materials happen to hold it together.

Y My next question circles back to something you mentioned earlier about moving from Korea to the US and having to adjust your craft to an entirely different measurement system and set of working conventions. I'm sure that process was frustrating at times, constantly recalibrating yourself around those differences. But beyond the inconveniences, were there also moments when working between worlds and languages felt inspiring or unexpectedly generative?

H When it comes to language, thinking in English and thinking in Korean feel very different to me. Once I started writing in English, I realized how difficult it was to translate those thoughts back into Korean. I don't consider myself a writer, but I think I'm a very good reader. I really love books, so I'm always careful about what I write and whether it might create misunderstandings. Luckily, Kathleen—who is also a professional editor—helped proofread my writing. For both of my books, Kathleen and Christopher helped edit and refine my language.

And for *Drops from the Air*, I'm still thinking about translating the English version back into Korean. The whole reason I made that book was because I wanted more people to know about abC. I love what they're doing, and I want to share it with others.

Y As someone who oversees every stage of making a book, from conceptualization to production to distribution and sales, what are some of your insights about the process?

H Printing books is actually very expensive, and so is

paper. For Frozen Island, I also used nine NFC stickers in every copy.

I sell my books through bookstores and distributors, and they usually take 50%, sometimes even 60%, of the retail price. So if a book sells for €24, I might only receive around €12, which mostly goes back into covering material and production costs. I still want to keep my books affordable so they remain accessible to the public.

Y Are you able to profit from your publications? Financially, do you see publishing as a self-sustaining practice, or is it something that still depends on having a daytime job?

H Having a daytime job definitely makes me feel safer. But with my books, I also try not to operate at a loss. So far there's usually been a small profit, not a huge amount, but enough to keep my publishing practice going.

There are also little strategies. For example, if you order paper for 500 copies instead of 100, the unit price becomes much cheaper. But at the same time, you don't want to hoard too many materials or create waste. And then you have to do your best to actually sell everything.

Y It's impressive that many of your books are sold out.

H Thanks. Frozen Island sold out around two years ago. I haven't been able to reprint it because one of the materials I used went out of stock.

Recently I found a replacement material, so I'm hoping to produce more copies this year. And my latest book is still very new, so I haven't fully distributed it yet. I'll probably focus on that during my summer break.

Y Given how much labor goes into coordinating production, sourcing materials, shipping, and finances, have you ever considered collaborating with a larger publishing house?

H That's a good question. Honestly, I haven't thought too seriously about working with a bigger publisher. I think one of the best things about independent publishing is having complete authorship. You can decide exactly what to show, and you can oversee everything—from writing, to printing, to distribution. You can choose every detail. There's a lot of freedom in that.

Of course, it can also be stressful when the budget is tight, or when your printer suddenly breaks and the ink stops working. But aside from those moments, I genuinely enjoy the process of making itself.

It's almost like a hobby. And hobbies cost money too. If your hobby is learning the ukulele, you still have to pay for lessons. But with this, at least I'm making some money back from it!

Y When you put it that way, it actually sounds like a pretty good deal.

H Haha, yeah. It's a good thing.

Y Besides books, you also make many other fascinating objects. I was browsing your website and kept going back to the wooden radio that also functions as a printer. It has this quality where you immediately want to touch it and play with it. You want to physically interact with it.

So I guess I'm curious about the difference between making an object, sometimes even a machine, versus, for example, coding a website. How do those processes differ for you?

H When I first came to RISD, I started by making interactive objects. For example, I made a camera that could immediately distribute the photo after someone took a picture with it.

Paul was one of the critics in my review for that project. He asked me: "If you're in a situation where you can't physically present the work yourself, how would you share it with other people?"

At the time, I couldn't answer his question. But I kept thinking about it for a long time. Eventually, one of the answers I arrived at was web publishing, thinking about online platforms as public spaces.

Y It's interesting that websites have appeared throughout our conversation as these highly public and accessible spaces. But at the same time, that accessibility isn't universal. Many platforms and digital tools simply don't function in the same way depending on where you are. Situations like that make me realize how much we take digital infrastructure for granted, and maybe also why people still hold onto physical objects so strongly.

H I think that makes a lot of sense. One of the reasons I created Air-Drop was because when they invited me to translate the Frozen Island experience into an exhibition in Hangzhou, I realized Google Maps wasn't available in China.

So I had to rethink the entire project and create something that didn't rely on Google Maps, while still inviting people to participate collectively and feel connected within the same shared space.

That's one of the benefits of working across multiple media. Books, websites, interactive objects, artworks, they all have different strengths and limitations. I choose whichever medium makes the most sense for a particular design situation.

Y Since you're teaching in BU's graphic design department now, I imagine many of your students are also passionate about making books, publishing work, and



building communities around their practices. What's one piece of advice you would give to someone interested in publishing?

H I think: just publish.

I struggled with the exact same fears during my MFA. I was doing an independent study with Kathleen Sleboda, and my project was to make a book. But I kept hesitating about whether I should actually publish it.

I was really stressed, and I kept asking Kathleen, "Is this okay? Should I really do this? Am I doing it right?" And she told me, "It's okay. Just keep going." Even then, I was still scared. But eventually I published the book, and afterward I realized something important: there's a threshold.

So many people have great ideas, great design, great content, but not many people actually publish their work, so nobody gets to encounter it. So I think the most important thing is: when you can, just go for it.

Y That's such good advice. And it's definitely easier to take advantage of institutional resources while you're still in school, especially through events supported by larger organizations like Multiple Formats, compared to handling everything completely on your own.

H I know artists who already graduated but still continue using facilities from their former schools.

Y Okay!

Y You mentioned earlier that you're an avid reader yourself, and throughout this conversation you've also encouraged people to simply put their work out into the world. That leads nicely into my final question about readership.

In recent years, book fairs seem to have become important physical spaces where people who make things can meet readers and often other makers as well. What has your relationship with readers been like so far?

H Honestly, it's been very surprising to me. I never expected these kinds of things to happen.

A lot of people have reached out to me after discovering my books somewhere in the world. Some email me or DM me. Sometimes I'll just be walking down the street or sitting in a café, and someone will come up and ask, "Hey, are you Halim?" and tell me they've read my book and liked it.

That's still very surprising to me. I think once you publish a book, its impact can become much larger than you ever expect.

Y How do you feel about those interactions? Do they

help shape your later projects, or do they mostly remain brief moments of appreciation?

H I really value both kinds of interactions: brief encounters where someone simply says hi, and longer conversations with people who genuinely want to know more about the work.

Both have helped me a lot, because simply having an audience is already incredibly motivating.

Back when I worked at Samsung, I occasionally made my own art after work. But Samsung had strict policies around employees producing outside work, which is actually why my Instagram handle became "alim" instead of "Halim." I wanted to disguise myself a little.

That period of my life felt very lonely. I had a daytime job, and after work I would make things that interested me, but nobody really saw them. Everything just stayed on my computer or in my room.

So having readers and audiences now means a lot to me. People also give feedback and perspectives that help me understand my work differently—what's working, what isn't, what resonates. That process helps you grow.

Sometimes I receive these very long emails from readers responding to my work, and they're incredibly touching. They often inspire the next project too.

Y I love that people reach out to you so personally. It reminds me of a comment that once went viral on Chinese social media. It was encouraging creators not to give up just because they don't see many comments or engagement online.

The comment said: "Readers are like cockroaches. If you see two, there are probably two hundred hiding in the dark."

H Oh my god. That's such an impactful comment.

Y Hahaha, disgusting but strangely heartwarming, right?

H Yes!

*more about
Halim!*

Originally from South Korea, Halim Lee is a multi-disciplinary designer based in Boston. She has received MFA from Rhode Island School of Design, and she is currently teaching at Boston University College of Fine Arts. Find her @alim.db or leehalim.com

1 Concept Development

Steps

- Identified the chair as both a functional object and a conceptual artifact
- Explored multiple design directions: starting with my experience at book fairs, researching chair designs and structures that are compatible with the publishing goals
- Developed sketches to test out interactivity and the balance between familiarity and inconvenience brought forward by the design

Materials Used

- Sketchbook and paper
- Pens, pencils, markers
- Reference images

Cost

- ~5

Help Received

- Feedback from peers during critiques
- Instructor guidance on design concept

2 Design Development

Steps

- Translated sketches into scaled drawings and digital models
- Iterated on dimension with chipboard mockups to understand the structure

Skills Needed

- Digital illustration and CAD modeling

Materials Used

- Rhino

Cost

- ~25

Help Received

- Technical support from classmates
- Design critique sessions

3 Material Sourcing

Steps

- Compared local suppliers for cost and availability

Materials Used

- Baltic birch plywood
- NFC tags

Cost

- ~130

Help Received

- Advice from fabrication lab staff and TAs

4 Fabrication

Steps

- Cut plywood sheets using CNC machine available at school
- Refined edges and surfaces through sanding
- Testing NFC tags' performance with the pocket structure and plywood thickness on top

Skills Needed

- CNC routing
- Sanding

Materials Used

- Rhino and MasterCam
- Plywood
- Sandpaper (80–320 grit range)

Cost

- ₺0 (consumables and shop usage fees)

Help Received

- CNC consultation with fabrication lab staff and TAs
- Woodshop instruction from technicians

5 Finishing

Steps

- Sanding refinement and coating
- Painting details

Materials Used

- Sandpaper
- Polyurethane spray
- Acrylic spray paint

Cost

- ~25

Help Received

- Guidance on finishing techniques from TAs and instructors

6 Assembly & Testing

Steps

- Assembly of all components
- Load testing for stability

7 Documentation

Steps

- Photographed each stage of the process.

Skills Needed

- Photography

Materials Used

- Camera
- Adobe Photoshop and Lightroom

Cost

- ~0

Help Received

- Equipment and modeling by friends

Overall Estimated Cost

- ~185 USD





